



Format: Feature Film

Genre: Gothic Drama/Historical Thriller

LOGLINE

When a privileged Southern debutante uncovers her family's deadly secret—that they framed an innocent Black man for murder in 1954—she must choose between protecting her inheritance and exposing a conspiracy that reaches the highest levels of society.

tone

Sharp Glass Southern Gothic meets **Big Little Lies**—lush, atmospheric, and psychologically complex with underlying menace. Think the visual elegance of **Bridgerton** with the moral complexity of **When They See Us** and the family secrets of **Succession**.

theme

Inherited Trauma & Moral Courage - How do we reconcile loving our families while confronting their sins? The story explores generational guilt, the price of privilege, and whether redemption is possible when built on others' suffering.

the pitch

It's 2025, but the ghosts of 1954 won't stay buried. Caroline Beaumont has everything—money, status, a debutante ball that's her coronation into Southern aristocracy. But when a mysterious stranger gives her evidence that her beloved grandmother murdered a woman and let an innocent Black musician hang for it, Caroline's perfect world shatters.

This isn't just about one family's secrets—it's about how entire systems protect themselves by sacrificing the vulnerable. As Caroline digs deeper, she discovers the conspiracy involves judges, newspapers, and the very pillars of her community.

The stakes escalate: Expose the truth and destroy her family, or stay silent and become complicit in injustice. When Caroline chooses truth at her debutante ball, she doesn't just lose her inheritance—she starts a reckoning that forces an entire community to confront its past.

DETAILED SYNOPSIS

ACT I: PERFECT FACADE

Caroline Beaumont, 22, is Southern royalty preparing for her debutante presentation. Beneath the pearls and charm, she struggles with anxiety and a growing sense that something is wrong with her picture-perfect life. When Elias Thorne approaches her at a garden party and gives her a locket, claiming her family gave it to his after "they killed him," Caroline's world tilts.

ACT II: CRACKS IN THE FOUNDATION

Caroline researches the name Elias mentioned—Samuel Thorne, lynched in 1954 for allegedly murdering socialite Vivian Shaw. The deeper she digs, the more connections she finds between Samuel and her grandmother Eleanor. A dying maid's confession reveals the impossible truth: Eleanor killed Vivian in jealous rage and orchestrated Samuel's lynching to cover it up.

ACT III: THE CONSPIRACY REVEALED

Eleanor admits her crime but defends it as survival—women didn't have choices in 1954. Caroline discovers that Judge Caldwell, a family friend, helped cover up the murder, suppressing evidence and silencing witnesses. The conspiracy reaches through decades, protecting one family while destroying another.

ACT IV: THE CHOICE

As Caroline's debutante ball approaches, the family pressures mount. Eleanor burns evidence. Caroline's therapist recommends institutionalization. The community turns against her. But with Elias's support and her own moral awakening, Caroline prepares to use her debutante presentation as a platform for truth.

ACT V: THE RECKONING

At her debutante ball, Caroline exposes her family's crimes in front of Georgia's elite. The revelation destroys her old life but begins a process of justice. Eleanor dies, Judge Caldwell resigns, and Caroline starts over—disinherited but free.

ACT VI: REDEMPTION

Caroline rebuilds her life around service and truth-telling. Samuel is posthumously exonerated. The community slowly begins to heal. Caroline and Elias find love built on honesty rather than social expectation.

CHARACTER BREAKDOWN

CAROLINE BEAUMONT (22, Lead)

Arc: Privileged princess to justice warrior

Casting Note: Needs vulnerability beneath steel—think Emma Stone's intensity with Saoirse Ronan's depth

ELEANOR BEAUMONT (78, Antagonist)

Arc: Regal matriarch to desperate criminal

Casting Note: Must command respect while hiding monster—Helen Mirren energy with Jessica Lange's darkness

ELIAS THORNE (26, Love Interest/Catalyst)

Arc: Angry activist to healing partner

Casting Note: Righteous anger softened by genuine heart—Michael B. Jordan's passion with John Boyega's intelligence

JUDGE HAROLD CALDWELL (82, Villain)

Arc: Respected jurist to exposed conspirator

Casting Note: Institutional authority hiding corruption—think Brian Cox in Succession

TALENT SUGGESTIONS & CASTING MOCK-UP

ROLE	ACTOR	WHY THEY FIT
Caroline Beaumont	Anya Taylor-Joy	Proven in period pieces (Emma, Queen's Gambit), conveys fragility and strength
	Sydney Sweeney	Euphoria proved range beyond pretty blonde, understands privilege's dark side
	Thomasin McKenzie	Jojo Rabbit showed ability to handle heavy themes with nuance
Eleanor Beaumont	Helen Mirren	Ultimate authority figure actress, can be sympathetic villain
	Glenn Close	Masters psychological complexity, awards magnet
	Jessica Lange	American Horror Story proves Gothic sensibility
Elias Thorne	John Boyega	Detroit/Small Axe showed righteous anger, Star Wars proved star power
	Stephan James	If Beale Street Could Talk, Homecoming—handles period and contemporary
	Lakeith Stanfield	Judas and Black Messiah proves ability with historical injustice stories
Judge Caldwell	Brian Cox	Succession success, authoritative presence
	John Lithgow	Range from comedy to menace

SOUTHERN BELLE'S SECRET



ANYA TAYLOR-JOY
CAROLINE BEAUMONT



SYDNEY SWEENEY
CAROLINE BEAUMONT



HELEN MIRREN
ELEANOR BEAMONT



JESSICA LANGE
ELEANOR BEAUMONT



JOHN BOYEGA
JUDGE CALDWELL



JOHN LITHGOW
JUDGE CALDWELL

DIRECTOR MATCH SUGGESTIONS

REGINA KING

- **Why:** One Night in Miami, Watchmen—expert at historical racial justice stories
- **Strength:** Actor-director who understands performance nuance
- **Awards:** Oscar winner, Emmy winner—prestige attached

BARRY JENKINS

- **Why:** Moonlight, If Beale Street Could Talk—visual poetry meets social justice
- **Strength:** Creates intimate character studies within larger social themes

KASI LEMMONS

- **Why:** Eve's Bayou, Harriet—Southern Gothic specialist
 - **Strength:** Understands family secrets and generational trauma
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LOOKBOOK & MOOD REFERENCES

Visual Style:

- **Bridgerton** - Lush period costumes, opulent settings
- **Big Little Lies** - Psychological tension beneath perfect surfaces
- **Lovecraft Country** - Historical horror, systemic racism as monster
- **The Crown** - Institutional power, family duty vs. personal morality

Tonal References:

- **When They See Us** - Historical injustice, systemic racism
 - **Sharp Objects** - Southern Gothic, family secrets
 - **Succession** - Privilege protecting itself, moral bankruptcy
 - **The Undoing** - Perfect lives hiding dark truths
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MARKETING HOOKS & TAGLINES

Primary Taglines:

- "Some legacies are worth breaking."
- "The truth will set you free... but first it will destroy you."
- "Not all family heirlooms should be inherited."

Campaign Hooks:

- **Social Justice Angle:** "A reckoning 70 years in the making"
 - **Family Drama:** "What would you sacrifice for the truth?"
 - **Historical:** "The past isn't past—it's just buried"
 - **Female Empowerment:** "She chose justice over jewels"
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TARGET AUDIENCE & MARKET

CORE AUDIENCE:

- **Primary:** Women 25-54, college-educated, socially conscious
- **Secondary:** Historical drama enthusiasts, social justice advocates
- **Tertiary:** Prestige TV consumers, awards season viewers

PLATFORM FIT:

- **Netflix:** Prestige limited series (When They See Us success)
 - **Hulu:** Female-driven psychological thrillers (The Handmaid's Tale audience)
 - **Apple TV+:** High-quality, awards-worthy content (The Morning Show demo)
 - **Lifetime/OWN:** Women-centered, socially relevant programming
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WHY IT SELLS

TRENDING THEMES:

- **Historical Reckoning:** Post-2020, audiences want stories about confronting systemic racism
- **Female Anti-Heroes:** Complex women making difficult choices (Mare of Easttown, The Undoing)
- **Family Secrets:** Succession, Big Little Lies prove appetite for dark family drama
- **Southern Gothic:** Sharp Objects, True Detective show enduring appeal

AWARDS POTENTIAL:

- **Acting Showcase:** Three powerhouse female roles (Caroline, Eleanor, supporting cast)
- **Social Relevance:** Addresses current conversations about historical justice

- **Technical Excellence:** Period costumes, production design, cinematography
 - **Writing Recognition:** Complex moral themes, strong dialogue
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COMPARABLE FILMS & SERIES

TONE & THEME:

- **When They See Us** (Netflix) - Historical racial injustice, systemic failures
- **Sharp Objects** (HBO) - Southern Gothic, family secrets, female psychology
- **Big Little Lies** (HBO) - Privileged women, dark secrets, moral complexity

COMMERCIAL BENCHMARKS:

- **The Undoing** (HBO) - 10.9M viewers premiere, sustained audience
 - **Mare of Easttown** (HBO) - 29M viewers total, cultural phenomenon
 - **When They See Us** (Netflix) - Global reach, awards sweep
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PRODUCTION VALUE

BUDGET CONSIDERATIONS:

- **Period Elements:** 1954 flashbacks require authentic costumes, sets, vehicles
- **Locations:** Georgia mansion, courtrooms, jazz clubs, churches
- **Talent:** A-list leads justify premium budget, ensure quality

PRODUCTION INCENTIVES:

- **Georgia Tax Credits:** 30% rebate, story's authentic Georgia setting
 - **Historical Accuracy:** Partnerships with civil rights organizations add authenticity
 - **Awards Strategy:** Prestige cast and subject matter position for major awards consideration
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STORY & HOOK – WHY THIS STORY MATTERS NOW

In 2025 America, we're still reckoning with historical injustices while new generations inherit both privilege and guilt. **The Southern Belle's Secret** doesn't just expose one family's crime—it asks whether redemption is possible when it requires destroying everything you've been taught to value.

This story resonates because:

- **It's personal and political:** Family loyalty vs. moral courage
- **It's timely:** Addresses ongoing conversations about historical accountability
- **It's universal:** Every family has secrets, every society has systemic sins
- **It's hopeful:** Shows that individuals can choose differently than their ancestors

The hook isn't just a murder mystery—it's a moral thriller about whether love means protecting family or protecting justice.

DEMOGRAPHICS & MARKETABILITY

AUDIENCE QUADRANTS:

- **Women 25-34:** Social justice themes, complex female protagonist
- **Women 35-54:** Family drama, moral complexity, prestige television
- **African American Audiences:** Historical justice themes, authentic representation
- **Southern Audiences:** Regional authenticity, family legacy themes

INTERNATIONAL APPEAL:

- **UK/European Markets:** Period drama expertise, social class themes
- **Streaming Global:** Universal themes of family, justice, moral courage
- **Awards Circuit:** Prestige subject matter, A-list cast appeal

FRANCHISE POTENTIAL:

- **Limited Series:** Perfect contained story with clear beginning/end
 - **Cultural Impact:** Could spark conversations about historical accountability
 - **Educational Partnerships:** Civil rights museums, historical societies
 - **Social Campaign:** #TruthAndReconciliation social media engagement
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THE BOTTOM LINE

The Southern Belle's Secret combines commercial appeal with cultural relevance. It's **Succession** in the antebellum South, **When They See Us** through the lens of privilege, **Big Little Lies** with historical weight.

This isn't just entertainment—it's a conversation starter about justice, family, and the price of truth. With the right cast and platform, it's both a ratings winner and an awards contender.

The time for this story is now. The audience is waiting. The impact will be lasting.

"Some stories demand to be told. This is one of them."